HARBOURLIGHT MEDIA

Advertising Clearance Policy

Document Policy 01 | Issue 5 | Owner: Clearance | Review cycle: every twelve months

1. Purpose

This policy says how Harbourlight Media clears advertising in the five restricted categories before it is transmitted: alcohol, betting and gaming, less healthy food, consumer credit, and medicines and health. It says who reviews a campaign, who decides it, what each decision means and what the agency is told.

It applies to every campaign in those categories booked on Harbourlight One, Harbourlight Sport, Harbourlight Drama and Harbourlight Life, whichever scheduling system the channel uses.

2. Roles

- **Clearance Executive** - works the clearance queue, reviews a campaign's copy and its booked spots, and writes the clearance assessment with a recommended decision.
- **Clearance Controller** - reads the assessment of a campaign they did not start, and decides the campaign. Only a Clearance Controller may clear a campaign or withdraw a spot.
- **Legal Adviser** - reviews a claim, an offer or a comparison when an executive asks, and records a legal review on the campaign.
- **Agency Liaison** - answers agencies' questions about the codes and about scheduling, and tells an agency the status of its own campaigns.

Harbourlight's audience planning team publishes the forecast under-18 audience index of every programme, as the Scheduling and Audience Rules describe.

3. Separation of review and clearance

The executive who reviews a campaign may not clear it. Every campaign is decided by a Clearance Controller who did not start its assessment, and the decision is recorded with the name of the Controller who took it and the reason, in their own words.

A Controller who started a campaign's assessment has reviewed it, and may not decide it; another Controller must.

An assessment - however it was produced - is a recommendation. No spot is cleared, no spot is withdrawn and nothing is sent to the agency until the decision is recorded. Tools may place and check every spot and draft the documents, but clearing a campaign is never a machine's decision.

4. What is checked

Every campaign is checked in two parts:

1. **The copy.** The claims it makes, any offer and whether its terms are shown, the performers, and everything the category's code says the copy must or must not do. The executive reads the notes on the campaign - the first read, any legal review, the agency's replies and any update - and the issue guide for the issue they raise.
2. **The booked spots.** Every spot is placed on its broadcast day, in or adjacent to the programmes around its break, and tested against the scheduling rules of the category's own code: restricted hours, the under-18 audience, programmes made for children, the daily limit and the separation.

Each category's rules are read from its own code and from no other document. The five codes share one layout and many of the same sentences. They differ in their figures, in the children's rule, which the medicines and health code applies only in a programme made for children, and in one exception that only the betting and gaming code has.

5. The three decisions

The Controller chooses one of three decisions, each open only as set out here:

- **CLEAR** - every booked spot is cleared. Open only when no spot breaks the code.
- **CLEAR WITH RESTRICTIONS** - the compliant spots are cleared and the spots that break the code are withdrawn. Open only when at least one spot breaks the code and at least one does not.
- **REJECT** - no spot is cleared. Always open, whatever the spots' results, for example when the copy cannot be cleared.

A decision the spots do not allow is refused: CLEAR while any spot breaks the code, and CLEAR WITH RESTRICTIONS when no spot breaks the code or when no spot complies.

The campaign's record moves from pending a decision to cleared, cleared with restrictions or rejected, and keeps the assessment, the decision, the reason, the spots cleared and withdrawn, and every document sent.

6. The restriction notice

When a campaign is cleared with restrictions, the agency is sent a restriction notice before the certificate is issued.

The notice is written for the agency: plain words, each withdrawn spot once with its channel, broadcast day and time and every rule it broke, and what to do next, taken from the section of the campaign's own code on re-booking a withdrawn spot.

It must never contain the internal assessment, a model's score, a note, the name of an executive or a Controller, or another agency's name.

7. The clearance certificate

A campaign that is cleared, with or without restrictions, is issued a clearance certificate. It must show:

- the campaign reference, the clock number, the advertiser and the product category
- each cleared spot on its own line, with its spot reference, channel, broadcast day and broadcast time
- no withdrawn spot, and no cleared spot twice
- the standing restrictions the category's code places on every cleared spot
- where a restriction notice was sent, a line saying the agency has been sent it

Every spot, time and rule on the certificate and on the notice is taken from the spot checks; none is worked out again by hand.

8. When a campaign is rejected

A rejected campaign is issued neither a certificate nor a notice. The Controller's reason is recorded, and the agency may submit the copy again, amended where it needs to be, as a new campaign.

9. The order campaigns are worked in

Campaigns are worked in order of their exposure: the under-18 audience their non-compliant spots would reach. For each spot that breaks the code, the forecast of under-18 viewers for the programme it is in is taken - or, for a spot in an end break, the larger of the two programmes' forecasts. The figures are added up for the campaign, in thousands, and the total is rounded once to one decimal place.

The largest exposure comes first. Between campaigns with the same exposure, the one whose first spot is transmitted earlier in the booking week comes first, and campaigns that still tie are taken in alphabetical order of campaign reference.

Each campaign's copy is also given an amendment score, the likelihood that the copy will need changes before it can be cleared. The score is shown to four decimal places and banded on the figure shown: HIGH from 0.60, MEDIUM from 0.30 and LOW below that.

10. Talking to agencies about a campaign

An Agency Liaison tells an agency about its own campaigns only - those of the agencies assigned to the liaison. Before a decision they give the status and when it last changed; after it, the decision, how many spots were cleared and withdrawn, and which documents the agency has been sent.

They never give a model's score, an index, a note or anything from the assessment.

A campaign booked by an agency that is not assigned to the liaison is treated as though it did not exist: the liaison says it cannot be found, in the same words used for a reference that does not exist. Agencies compete for the same airtime, and a campaign is confidential between its agency and Harbourlight.

Questions about the codes and about the Scheduling and Audience Rules are answered for anyone, because the codes are published to agencies.